CRISIS RESOURCE GUIDE

When Money Feels Like an Emergency

A short guide for right now — not forever.

If you're reading this, something financial probably feels urgent right now. This guide isn't about fixing your relationship with money — that's a longer conversation for another day. This is just about today: what needs attention first, and where to get real help.

A note on what this is

This guide offers general information and points you toward professional help — it isn't personalized legal, tax, or financial advice, and it isn't a substitute for a licensed professional who can look at your specific situation. Programs, prices, and eligibility change and vary by state — confirm details with the program itself before you apply.

If Your Safety Is at Risk — Start Here

If you or someone in your household is in immediate danger, that comes before anything else in this guide.

Immediate safety resources

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline — call or text 988, any time.

National Domestic Violence Hotline — 1-800-799-7233.

First: Sort What's Today, This Week, and This Month

Financial emergencies feel like everything is on fire at once. Almost nothing actually needs to happen in the next hour. Try sorting what's in front of you into three piles:

- **Today:** anything involving safety, shutoff notices with a same-day deadline, or a court date.
- **This week:** collections calls, overdue bills without an immediate shutoff, appointments to make.
- **This month:** anything that's stressful but has no hard deadline yet.

You can only act on one thing at a time. Sorting first keeps you from spending your energy on the wrong fire.

Ask for Time: Calling Your Lenders and Creditors

One of the most useful things you can do — and one of the least used — is to call before you miss a payment. Companies deal with hardship every day, and many have options they won't mention unless you ask.

- Ask whether they can move your payment due date to line up with when you actually get paid.
- Ask whether they offer a hardship program, a reduced or deferred payment, or a one-time skipped payment.
- Ask what happens to interest, fees, and your credit reporting if you skip or defer — a skipped payment sometimes just gets added to the end of the loan, and sometimes interest keeps building.
- Get any agreement in writing or by confirmation email before you rely on it.
- Don't simply stop paying and hope. An arrangement you asked for is very different from a payment you missed.

Before you call, have your account number, a simple one-line explanation ("I lost income and I want to stay current — what options do you have?"), and a pen ready. If the first person can't help, politely ask for the hardship or loss mitigation department.

If Housing Is at Risk

If you rent:

- Contact your landlord early — before a missed payment becomes a legal filing. Many are more willing to work out a plan before the fact than after.
- Ask about rental assistance programs. Funding differs by city and county, so dial 211 or contact your local housing authority or Community Action Agency to find what's open near you.
- Local charities — including Catholic Charities, the Salvation Army, and St. Vincent de Paul — sometimes help with a month's rent or a security deposit.
- If you've already received a legal notice, a free legal aid organization can explain your rights and timeline.

If you own and are behind on your mortgage:

- Call your mortgage servicer (the company you send the payment to) and ask about loss mitigation options: forbearance, a repayment plan, or a loan modification. Servicers generally work with people who reach out early.
- Ask whether any state or local homeowner assistance programs are available — a housing counselor will know what's currently open.
- A HUD-approved housing counselor can review your specific situation for free and walk you through your options. Be cautious of anyone who charges an upfront fee to "save your home."

If Utilities Are at Risk

- Call the provider directly and ask about hardship programs, payment plans, or a later due date — most have one, even if it isn't advertised.
- Apply for utility assistance. The Low Income Home Energy Assistance Program (LIHEAP) is a federal program that helps cover energy costs, and many local utilities and charities run their own funds.
- Ask about shutoff protections — some states and utilities limit disconnections for certain situations, such as extreme weather or a medical need.
- Dial 211 to be connected to local emergency assistance programs, regardless of where you live.

Benefits Worth Applying For

Applying for help is a strategy, not a failure — these programs exist for exactly this season. Eligibility depends on your household size, income, and state, and applying costs nothing, so it's worth finding out rather than assuming.

- **SNAP (food benefits / EBT):** Apply through your state's benefits office or online portal. It can free up real money in your monthly budget for rent and utilities.
- **Other food help:** Ask about WIC if there are young children or someone is pregnant, and about free or reduced-price school meals for school-age kids.
- **Health coverage (Medicaid):** If your household has no or low income, you may qualify through your state. Applying through your state's marketplace or Medicaid office will tell you.
- **Lifeline (phone and internet):** A federal program that provides a monthly discount on phone or internet service, and many providers offer a free basic cell plan. If you receive SNAP, Medicaid, or certain other benefits, you may already qualify. Apply at lifelinesupport.org.
- **Low-cost home internet:** Some internet providers offer low-cost plans for households on SNAP or other assistance. Call your current provider and ask. (The federal Affordable Connectivity Program ended in 2024, so Lifeline and provider plans are the main options now.)
- **Discounted memberships:** Amazon (Prime Access) and Walmart (Walmart+ Assist) offer discounted memberships — roughly half price — if you receive EBT or Medicaid. They're only worth

it if you'll actually use the free shipping or delivery to save money, so don't add a subscription just because it's discounted. Check the company's site for current prices and sign-up steps.

- **Unemployment insurance:** If you lost your job, file for unemployment insurance right away through your state workforce agency — benefits generally don't start until you apply.

Help Close to Home

Some of the most practical help is local, and a lot of it is free.

- Tell your child's school you need support. Counselors and social workers can connect families to food, clothing, school supplies, and local assistance — and if your family has lost housing, ask about services for students experiencing homelessness.
- Your church or faith community may have a food pantry, a benevolence fund, or members who can point you to help. You don't have to be a regular attendee to ask.
- Your public library is more than books: free computers and Wi-Fi for applications and job searches, help with forms, and often connections to local services.
- Local food banks and community pantries — search by zip code at feedingamerica.org/find-your-local-foodbank.
- 211 can tell you what's actually open in your area right now.

If Debt Collectors Are Calling

- You have the right to request any debt claim in writing before agreeing to pay anything.
- Avoid making a payment out of pressure or fear before you've confirmed the debt is accurate and yours.
- A nonprofit credit counselor (not a for-profit debt settlement company) can review your full picture with you at low or no cost.

If Taxes Feel Like a Crisis

- The IRS has hardship and payment plan options — avoiding contact almost always makes a tax issue worse, not better.
- The Taxpayer Advocate Service is a free, independent office inside the IRS specifically for situations that feel like an emergency.
- A tax professional can help you understand options specific to your situation — general information here isn't a substitute for that conversation.

A National Resource Directory

These are established, reputable organizations available regardless of where you live in the U.S.

If You Need	Resource	Contact
Immediate safety support	988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline	Call or text 988
Domestic violence support	National Domestic Violence Hotline	1-800-799-7233
Local help of any kind	211 — connects you to local assistance wherever you live	Dial 211 or visit 211.org
Rent or mortgage trouble	HUD-approved housing counselor (free)	findahousingcounselor.hud.gov

If You Need	Resource	Contact
Mortgage servicer problems	Consumer Financial Protection Bureau — mortgage help	consumerfinance.gov/owning-a-home/mortgage-help
Food assistance	SNAP (EBT) — apply through your state; local food banks	Search "[your state] SNAP application"; feedingamerica.org/find-your-local-foodbank
Free or discounted phone / internet	Lifeline (federal program)	lifelinesupport.org
Lost your job	Unemployment insurance — through your state workforce agency	dol.gov/general/topic/unemployment-insurance
Overwhelming debt	National Foundation for Credit Counseling (nonprofit)	nfcc.org
Legal questions or eviction defense	LawHelp — free and low-cost legal aid directory	lawhelp.org
Tax debt or IRS trouble	IRS Taxpayer Advocate Service	irs.gov/advocate or 1-877-777-4778

This Isn't Forever

An emergency is not a life sentence, and it isn't a reflection of who you are with money. Most people who feel like this today won't feel like this in six months — especially once the most urgent piece is handled.

When you're in a steadier place and want to do the deeper work — understanding not just what to do in a crisis, but why money feels the way it does for you — there's a free weekly community called the Long Money Circle. No pressure, no cost, just a place to keep going when you're ready.

You're going to be okay. Let's get through today first.